

Screens, Toys & Tools — Module 01: Systems — Think About It

Part A: Family Discussion Questions

1. How many screens are in your house? (Count them all — TV, phone, tablet, computer, smartwatch).
2. Is the internet a system? What are its parts? (Computers, cables, servers, websites, users).
3. What is a "Digital Neighborhood"? (The online places your family visits — websites, apps, games).
4. Are there safe and unsafe places in your digital neighborhood, just like in a real neighborhood?
5. What are the "boundaries" of your family's media use? (Screen time limits, approved apps, no phones at dinner).
6. What happens when there is too much screen time and not enough play time? (The system gets out of balance).
7. What is the difference between a toy and a tool? (A tool helps you accomplish a task; a toy helps you learn through play — some things are both!).
8. Why do phones beep and buzz? (Notifications are the system demanding your attention).
9. What would a day without any screens look like? Would that be fun, boring, or hard?
10. How does your family decide which technology is helpful and which is not?

Part B: Hands-On Activities and Reflection

1. Do a "Screen Census": Walk through your house and count every screen. Draw a map showing where they are. Are there screen-free rooms? Should there be?
2. Sort your family's apps and shows into categories: Learning, Entertainment, Communication, Games. Which category has the most? Is that the right balance?
3. Turn off all screens for one hour. What does the family do instead? Write or draw about how it felt. Was it hard? Easy? Fun?

4. Make a "Media Map" of your home: Draw your house and label where each type of media lives. Then draw the "real world" activities that happen in the same spaces.
5. Count the notifications that come to one device in one hour. Each notification is the system asking for attention. Which ones are truly important?
6. Look at one toy and one app that teach the same thing (like counting). Compare them: Which uses more senses? Which keeps you more focused? Which do you learn more from?
7. Build a "Device" out of cardboard and craft supplies (a pretend phone, tablet, or robot). What does it do? What are its rules? You just designed a system!
8. List three things technology helps your family do better. List three things it makes harder. Discuss: How can we keep the good and reduce the bad?
9. Together, draw your "Ideal Digital Neighborhood" — what apps, shows, and websites would be on the map? What would NOT be there?
10. At the end of the day, ask: Did I use technology today, or did technology use me? The answer tells you whether you were the agent or the system was.